

Retention Playbook P2 - Plan-Commitment Upsell

When this applies

This playbook targets subscribers on short payment_plan_days cycles (for example, month-to-month or 30-day plans) as opposed to longer commitment plans. Short-cycle subscribers churn at a materially higher rate than subscribers on longer plans, because every cycle boundary is a fresh decision point to leave, whereas a longer plan removes several of those decision points entirely.

This is a commitment-structure risk, distinct from engagement or price risk: a short-cycle subscriber can be highly engaged and still churn simply because they are asked to re-decide every month.

Recommended interventions

Offer a plan-length upgrade (e.g. move a 30-day plan to a 90-day or annual plan) at renewal time, framed around convenience ("stop worrying about renewing every month") rather than around price. A modest per-cycle discount (5-10%) tied specifically to the longer commitment is appropriate here and should be framed as a loyalty rate, not a churn-prevention discount - it is being paid for by locking in the commitment, not by the subscriber's risk level.

For subscribers who decline the upgrade twice, do not push a third time in the same quarter; over-offering a plan-length upsell to a subscriber who has explicitly signalled a preference for short commitment increases the chance they cancel outright rather than just declining the upsell.

Interaction with other drivers

Plan-commitment risk frequently co-occurs with auto-renew risk (P1), since a short cycle simply gives auto-renew more chances to be tested. When both are present, lead with the plan-length upsell first - a longer plan structurally reduces how often the auto-renew risk can even manifest, whereas fixing auto-renew alone leaves the short-cycle exposure in place for the next month.